

The greatest World Cup? Every time

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Hyperbole accompanies every World Cup. How else can we justify staying up horribly late or getting up ridiculously early and disrupting our daily schedule? "This is the greatest World Cup," we tell one another. It is a quadrennial ritual.

Perhaps we are right every time. **Technology has made every edition appear superior. Better cameras, smarter analysis and faster statistics. Graphics telling us a midfielder covered 11.3 kilometres before misplacing a five-metre pass.** VAR examines a toe with the seriousness of Hercule Poirot studying a clue in a murder case. We know more than ever before, although whether we understand more is debatable.

I remember watching the 1990 World Cup not so much for the goals or the final, but for the manner in which our then two-year-old son recognised Maradona every time he came on screen. We may not remember tournaments, but we remember ourselves watching them.

Tournaments serve as family albums. A friend remembers an uncle who needed to have everything explained to him (offside, what offside?) and who passed away soon after. I never watched a game with my father because we lived in different cities, but we spoke to each other every day after a match. He had played football, and so had strong opinions. In most cases, football merely supplied the soundtrack.

The best? 1970 and Pele? 1974 and Cruyff (although the Dutch did not win)? 1986 and Maradona? 1998 and Zidane? 2022 and Messi? You can tell a person's age by



Etched in memory: For one generation, this was football's defining image. Every World Cup has one that lingers long after the final whistle. AP

the World Cup he claims is the best.

There are other reasons for thinking the latest is the greatest. Marketing geniuses tell us it is the most inclusive, the most connected, the most watched and the most innovative. It's their job.

Actually, every World Cup is the greatest for someone. For the child who remembers not because of amazing powers of recall, but because family stories get repeated. For the substitute who plays just 10 unforgettable minutes. For a nation which receives action in high definition for the first time. Sport always finds new ways to matter.

Nostalgia, meanwhile, edits ruthlessly. It deletes the goalless draws, the tedious stalemates and the evenings when nothing happened except the commentator discovering interesting facts about the local cuisine. Memory is a great

highlights package. Perhaps that is why every new tournament feels better than the last.

When the final whistle blows, the verdict arrives on cue: "The best World Cup ever." Even if the person with the greatest influence might have been a President who got a red card reversed or another president (he of FIFA, but behaving like a potentate) who made it happen. A door has been opened, and there's no telling who will walk through it, from politicians to mafia dons.

All this has joined the museum of personal memory. We curate our own gallery.

Four years from now, another tournament will begin. There will be new stars, new controversies, and new technology. Someone will insist that football has reached heights never before imagined. Someone else, older, will smile knowingly.